

Mexico City

In 2002, Giuliani Partners LLC gained a \$4.3 million contract with Carlos Slim Helu, one of the wealthiest men in the world, to consult on crime reduction in Mexico City. Giuliani was known, and often lauded, for his 'tough on crime' approach, and Giuliani Partners LLC promoted New York-style zero tolerance policing across the world.

Giuliani Partners LLC, under the leadership of former New York mayor Rudy Giuliani, was brought in to offer a comprehensive plan to reform Mexico City's policing strategies and issued 146 recommendations. Specific recommendations included cracking down on informal street vendors known as "franeleros" and "squeegee men" and setting up anti-graffiti units, along with less controversial measures such as creating an official record of bus drivers. Although recommendation No. 124 calling to "Monitor indigent street children" included the provision to "create shelters for high risk and addiction cases," the suggestions from Giuliani LLC were criticized by groups representing homeless communities and street children. The city ombudsman, Emilio Alvarez Icaza, speaking on behalf of NGOs that work with street children, warned the government against criminalizing poverty and called for human rights to not be sacrificed in the name of law and order.

Inspired by the zero-tolerance ethos, the Mexico City Legislative Assembly passed a "Law of Civic Culture" shortly before the report was published. This law increased the penalties for several minor offenses, including requesting a tip for "fire-eating", a common practice among street children. It expanded the number of punishable minor offenses from 22 to 43. By 2005, an average of 231 people were being detained daily for offenses related to the new law. The emphasis on 'zero tolerance' policing targeted individuals working in the informal economy and further marginalized vulnerable groups such as homeless children.

While many of the most vulnerable residents of Mexico City were harmed by the turn to zero tolerance policing, Carlo 'Slim' Helu, the man paying for Giuliani LLC's services, benefited economically. Experts and residents of Mexico City widely perceive that the report recommendations were only implemented "in the tourist zones", the historic city center. As scholars Mitchell and Beckett note, police harassment and/or eviction of marginalized communities opens up neighborhoods to financial speculation and development. Helu, the businessman who paid for Giuliani LLC to consult the Mexico City government on zero-tolerance policing, had acquired several properties in the historic central district of Mexico City which he developed into loft apartments. His properties, which were in the areas most impacted by the recommendations, appreciated in value.

Despite the consulting contract ending abruptly due to a breach of agreement, the law enforcement strategies introduced by Giuliani's firm had lasting effects. In a 2003 letter, the Lawyers' Committee for Human Rights wrote to then Mexico City Mayor Marcelo Ebrard "Perhaps the greatest disadvantage of the [Giuliani] approach is the pressure it places on the police to solve problems that are largely beyond its competence to resolve...". As city ombudsman Emilio Alvarez Icaza stated in 2003, beggars, street-hawkers, 'squeegee men', and sex workers in Mexico City were economic victims rather than criminals who should be dealt with by the police.

Citations:

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